

A Community-Engaged Curriculum Design Model for Culturally-Responsive Tech Consulting

Annie Zhou, Kristin Seefeldt, Julie Hui, Christie Baer,
Lutalo Sanifu, Tawanna R. Dillahunt

University of Michigan



Study Context

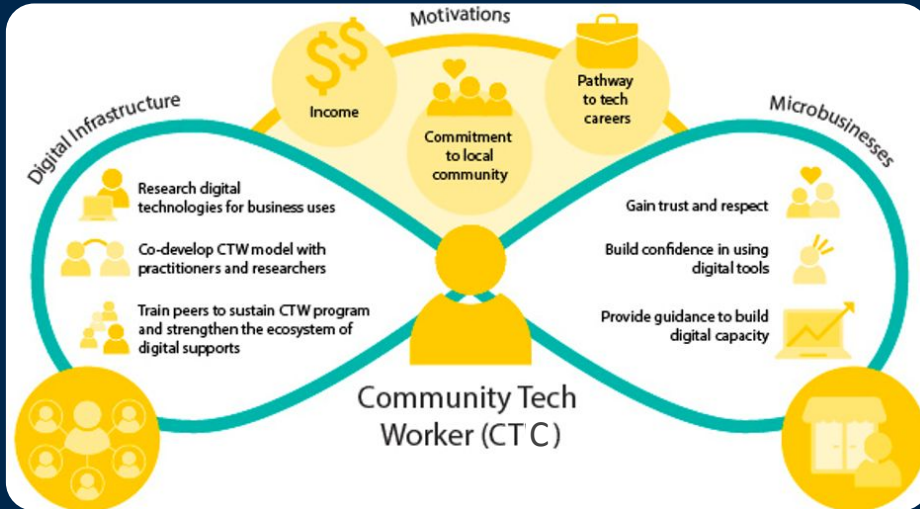
Detroit neighborhoods

- Detroit's East Jefferson and Livernois–McNichols corridors
- Most businesses in the neighborhoods are **Black-women-owned**, primarily in restaurants, retail, and e-commerce.
- Previous studies: Minority small businesses are actively building their **digital capacity** while facing significant **barriers**.



Study Context

Community Tech Consultants (CTC) model



— CTC Model



— Resident CTC working with a client

Study Context

Student CTC course on social media content consulting

- Target learners: first-year students from the School of Education LEAPS program at Marygrove
- Previous studies: reciprocal capacity building and cultural responsiveness training (Hui et al. 2023)



A community-engaged curriculum for culturally responsive tech consulting



What are the key design elements of a community-engaged curriculum that prepares university students for **culturally responsive** tech consulting?

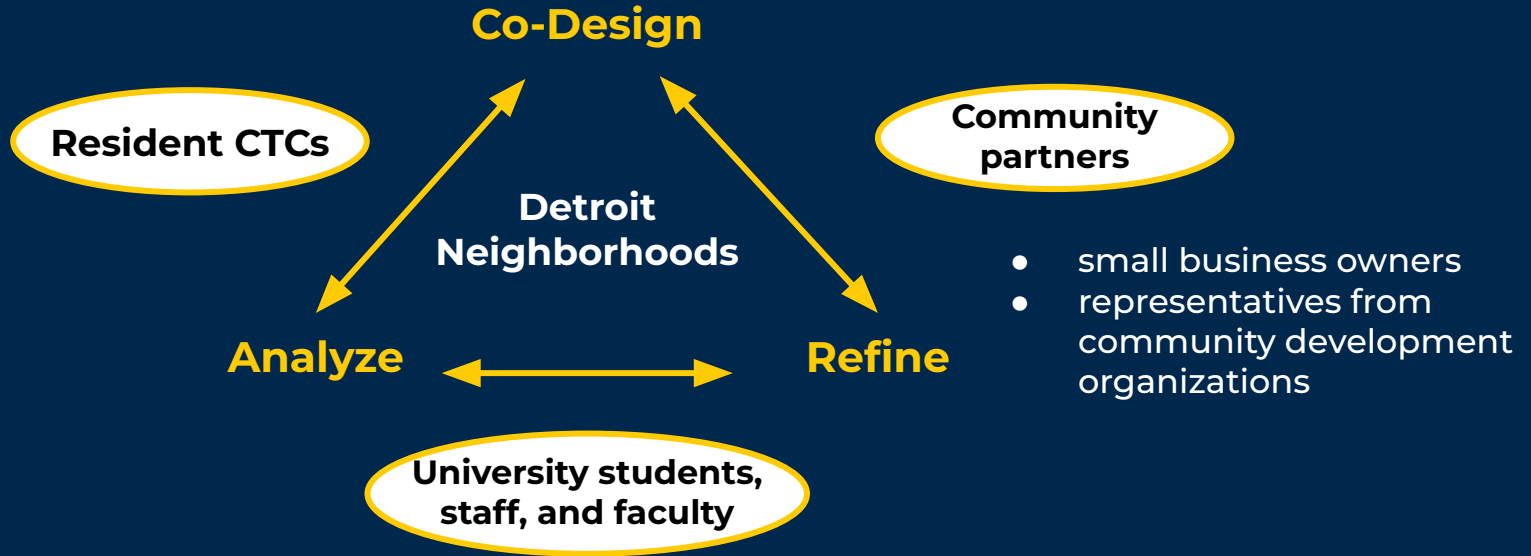
Guiding Pedagogical Principle

Asset-based pedagogies: teaching and learning that acknowledge, leverage, and sustain students' and communities' cultures:

- Align both the curriculum design **process** and the curriculum **content** with students' prior knowledge and experiences, as well as the cultures and practices of local communities
- Frame the development of students' capacity for culturally responsive community engagement as an **overarching goal** and align the curriculum's structure, content, and pedagogy to support it

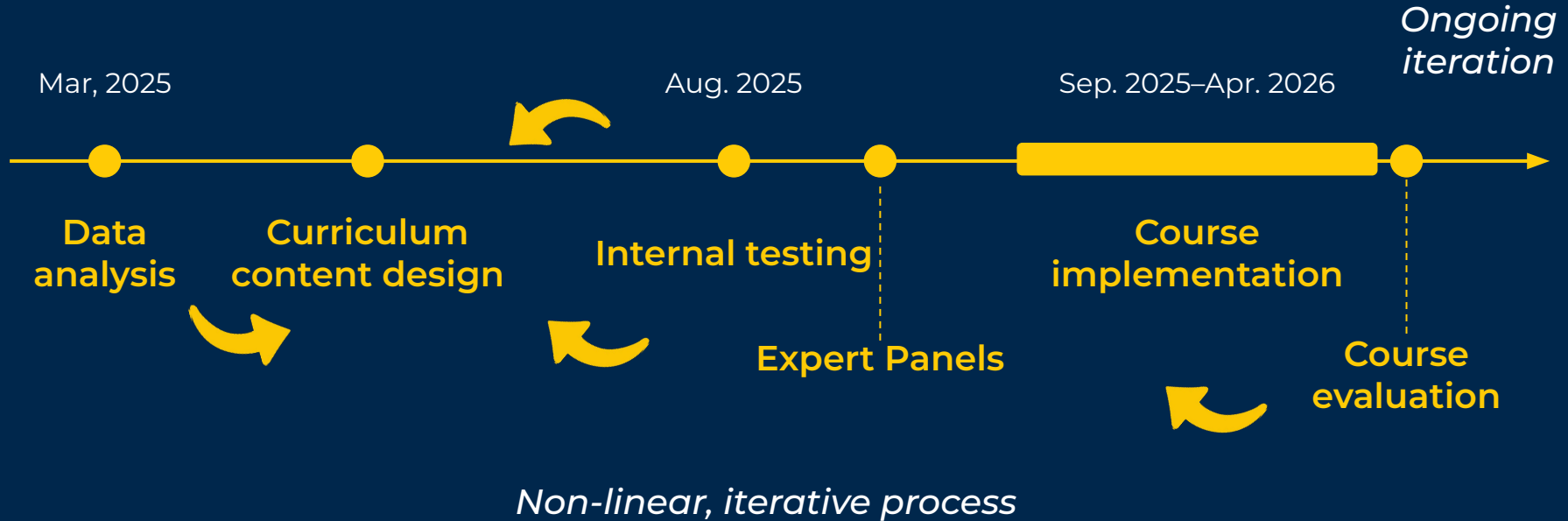
Study Design

Design-based research



Study Design

Study timeline



Study Design

Dataset

1

Interviews with
resident CTCs

2

Observations &
field notes

3

Interviews with
instructors

4

Discussions
with
community
partners

5

Learner needs
assessment

Evaluation of previous resident CTCs training

Study Design

Insights from previous training evaluation

Authentic learning
Relationship building

CTC A: *The **business people** came and talked with us—we saw what daily life is like for a tech consultant, how they approach their work and build different **partnerships**.*

Peer support and
collaboration

CTC B: *I'm so happy that you **paired us together** because his expertise in tech and his willingness to share resources and discuss upcoming events have helped me stay up to date with the field.*

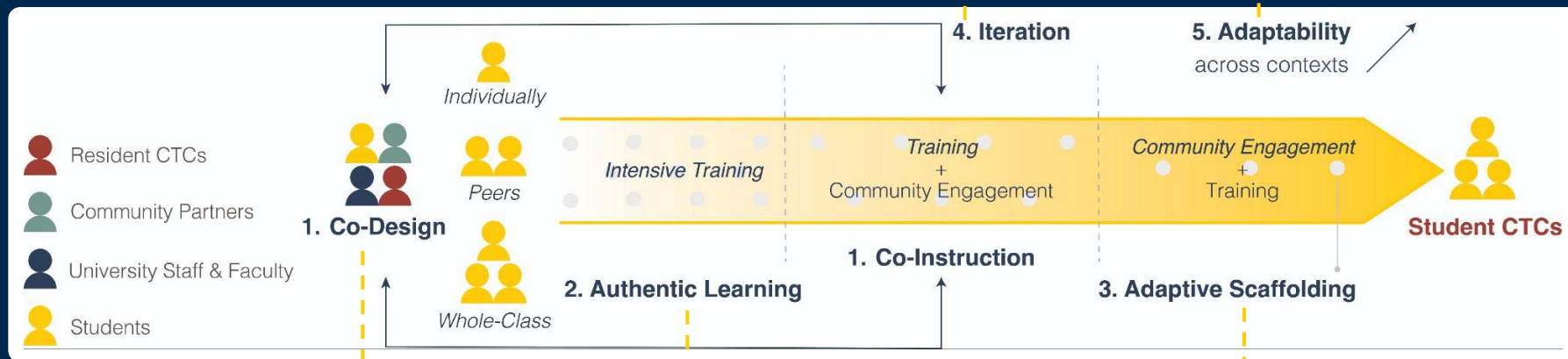
Capacity building

Instructor A: *It was my hope that we would create something that could be **sustainably successful** for an individual.*

Study Context	Study Design	Curriculum Design	Implementation & Evaluation	Conclusion	Challenges & Reflections
Learning Objectives					
1. Apply digital skills/instruction in culturally responsive and community-centered ways that support diverse small businesses.	1.1 Reflect critically on personal cultural perspectives and demonstrate cultural awareness by listening actively, responding respectfully, and engaging collaboratively with community members from diverse backgrounds.				
	1.2 Recognize how Detroit’s cultural, historical, and economic landscape—including its diverse neighborhoods and key landmarks—shapes the local business environment and community values, building a foundation for engaging with communities in diverse settings.				
	1.3 Identify the cultural and community-based resources that support Detroit businesses and understand how local entrepreneurs contribute to community resilience and innovation, developing transferable insights into entrepreneurship in diverse contexts.				
2. Co-design sound digital solutions based on small business owners’ values, needs, and goals.	2.1 Explore the affordances and limitations of digital technologies within specific community contexts.				
	2.2 Co-design thoughtful digital solutions that align with small business owners’ values, needs, and goals by analyzing feedback from community members, considering cultural and community contexts, and translating insights into practical, respectful strategies.				
	2.3 Develop a professional portfolio demonstrating community-engaged client work and applied digital skills.				

- Formative assessment
- Curriculum evaluation

- Conceptual learning
- Local case studies
- Structured reflections



- Community partners
- University stakeholders (faculty, staff, and students)

- Cultural asset scavenger hunt
- Canvassing

- Real-time coaching
- Reflective prompts
- Regular check-ins

Curriculum Implementation

Fall 2025 and Winter 2026 semesters



Improv and Mock
Interview

Module	Lesson	Brief Description and Learning Objectives
Module 1: Understand Self & Community Explore your identity while learning about the city's cultural, historical, and economic landscape.	True Colors Activity	To reflect on how your mind works and shapes your interactions.
	Cultural Asset Scavenger Hunt	To discover the city's rich cultural landscape by exploring its murals, markets, landmarks, and local stories.
	Business Ecosystem Panel	To explore the factors that help businesses thrive through a panel discussion with neighborhood entrepreneurs.
	Canvassing	To explore the neighborhood's entrepreneurship and community cultures, and to cultivate an entrepreneurial mindset while developing foundational skills in real-world contexts.

Curriculum outline excerpt

Curriculum Evaluation

Post-course learner interviews

I feel like **canvassing** really lets me step out of my comfort zone because that was a big challenge for me. But after I did it, I had a **sense of satisfaction** that I actually did something and I **challenged myself** and got something bigger than doing activities in classrooms.

Learner A

I think CTC is probably the most important experience I've had in my freshman year, because it **supplements everything else** so well and it gives me the **real world** to bring the ideas that I'm gaining in classes and other stuff.

Learner B

Curriculum Evaluation

Post-course instructor interviews

I think if there are a couple of things that would have to happen that are really the magic behind this: one is **catching them doing something right** and **pointing it out to desensitize**, to **get rid of that fear of failure**.

Instructor A

Instructor B

I would say they **slow us down**; and not in a bad way.

Conclusion

- **Curriculum design model** with five elements:
 - co-design and co-instruction
 - authentic learning
 - adaptive scaffolding
 - iteration
 - adaptability
- **Cultural responsiveness** in community-engaged learning:
 - designing **curricula** that are responsive to students' and communities' cultures
 - cultivating **students' capabilities** for culturally responsive community engagement

Challenges & Reflections

1

Scalability

How might we design the curriculum/program for **adaptation** across community settings while remaining responsive to local needs, values, and assets?

2

Sustainability

How might we **sustain** the curriculum/program through long-term relationships, reciprocal capacity-building, and continuous iteration?

Thank You!



CTC Program



DNEP



LEAPS Program

chenxiz@umich.edu

No Term

Home

Announcements 

Assignments

Discussions

Grades

People

Pages 

Files

Syllabus

Rubrics

Quizzes 

Modules 

Collaborations

Chat

Teaching Evaluations

Outcomes 

BigBlueButton 

Settings

Module 1: Understand Self & Community

Welcome to the Course 

True Colors Activity 

True Colors Test 

True Colors Discussion Video 

True Colors Activity Reflection & Discussion 

Story Circles 

An Introduction to Story Circles 

Story Circles Discussion 1 

Story Circles Discussion 2 

Story Circles Reflection 
10 pts

Cultural Asset Scavenger Hunt 

An Introduction to Scavenger Hunt 

Scavenger Hunt Group Activity 
10 pts

Scavenger Hunt Group Activity Rubric 

Scavenger Hunt Reflection & Discussion 